Population employees have said this would be the Rohingyas'"last chance to register", and that "the conditions after this will be very different, especially with a new government in place", without specifying the reason for this perception.[21] In this situation, franchise was linked to citizenship, constituting a departure from past practices.

In 2010, the holders of temporary registration cards (TRCs) — so-called 'white cards' — were encouraged to take part in the elections. The outgoing SPDC regime distributed more white cards to increase the turnout for the USDP. However, the political rights of the formally stateless population were again infringed in late 2014 with an amendment of the political party registration law, which deprived white-card holders of the right to found or be members of political parties. As a consequence, the UEC required all parties to change their membership lists.

The next controversy arose at the beginning of 2015, with a Pyidaungsu Hluttaw draft national referendum bill, stimulating a new debate around temporary identity certificate enfranchisement. Ashin Wirathu said in a press statement, "I warn [parliament] not to betray the over 50 million national people by giving priority to the over one million illegal people. If you allow them to vote in the coming election, I will lead the people to fight against them all."[22] Other press statements called for public protests in Rakhine State and Yangon. The president turned the situation around by declaring the expiry of white cards altogether by 31 March 2015. The two-month period for collection started on 1 April, and facilitated by village leaders the cards were handed in without much resistance. As a consequence, white-card holders were not included in the voter list updates, which started about the same time these decisions were taken. The electoral laws were later amended accordingly; it was estimated that half a million voters were disenfranchised by these changes in the legal framework (TNI 2015, p. 5).

A year ahead of the ballot, fears were high that Rakhine State was steering towards another significant outbreak of violence and potential humanitarian disaster. From a perspective of electoral security, the large-scale disenfranchisement of formerly eligible voters decreased the risk for violence to escalate, but the environment remained charged. The electoral contest turned into a battle between the ANP, the USDP, and the NLD. The ANP emerged as the most successful party, albeit with lower results than anticipated and more seats lost to the NLD than expected.[23] Following the expiry of white cards, Muslim voters hardly participated in the electoral